HIERARCHY IN MARIANNE MOORE'S "THE BUFFALO" | *A Literary & Digital Analysis*

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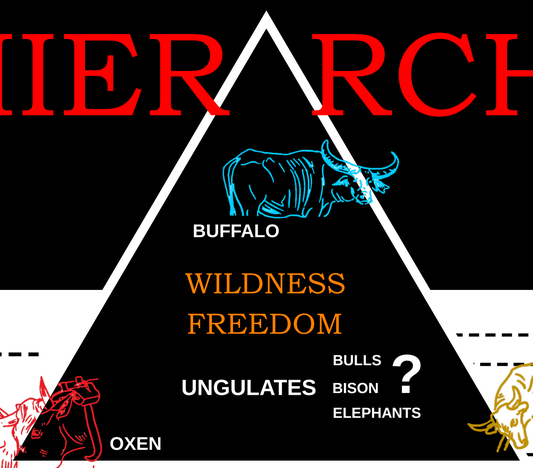
University at Buffalo

Moore Archive

University at Buffalo University Honors College

University at Buffalo Digital Humanities Initiative at Buffalo College of Arts and Sciences

CURCA CENTER FOR UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCH AND CREATIVE ACTIVITIES



linguistics

mercantilism

imperialism

biographical context

sentiment analysis

mythology

THE BUFFALO

Black in blazonry means
prudence; and niger, unpropitious. Might
hematite—
black, compactly incurved horns on bison
have significance? The
soot-brown tail-tuft on
a kind of lion –

tail; what would that express?
And John Steuart Curry's Ajax pulling
grass—no ring
in his nose—two birds standing on the back?

. . . . . .

The modern
ox does not look like the Augsburg ox's
portrait. Yes,
the great extinct wild Aurochs was a beast
to paint, with stripe and six-
foot horn-spread—decreased
to Siamese-cat-

Brown Swiss size or zebu-
shape, with white plush dewlap and warm-blooded
hump; to red-
skinned Hereford or to piebald Holstein. Yet
some would say the sparse-haired
buffalo has met
human notions best—

unlike the elephant,
both jewel and jeweller in the hairs
that he wears—
no white-nosed Vermont ox yoked with its twin
to haul the maple-sap,
up to their knees in
snow; no freakishly

Over-Drove Ox drawn by
Rowlandson, but the Indian buffalo,
albino-
footed, standing in a mud-lake with a
day's work to do. No white
Christian heathen, way-
laid by the Buddha,

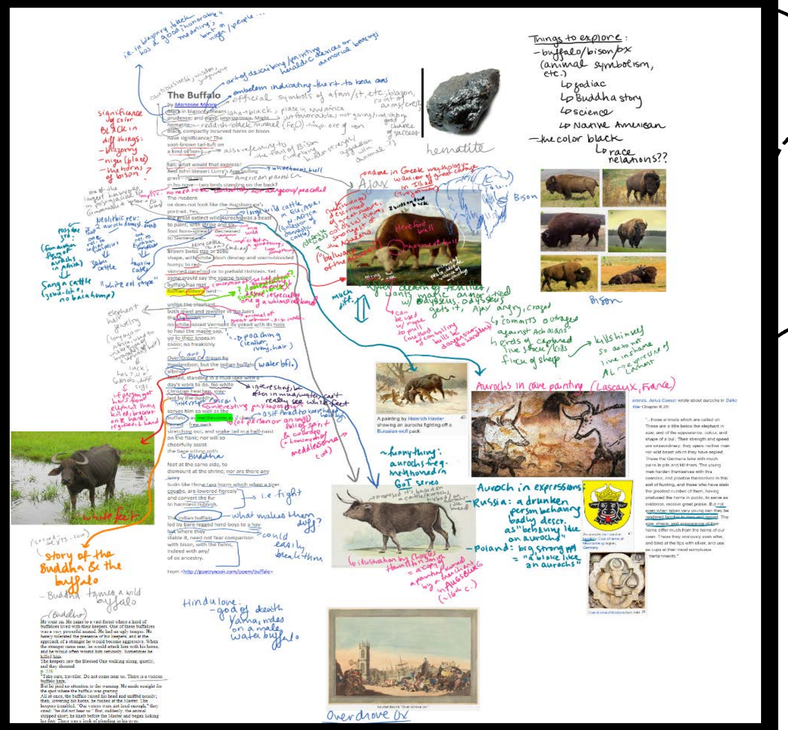
serves him so well as the
buffalo—as mettlesome as if check-
reined—free neck
stretching out, and snake tail in a half-twist
on the flank; nor will so
cheerfully assist
the Sage sitting with

feet at the same side, to
dismount at the shrine; nor are there any
ivory
tusks like those two horns which when a tiger
coughs, are lowered fiercely
and convert the fur
to harmless rubbish.

The Indian buffalo,
led by bare-legged herd-boys to a hay
hut where they
stable it, need not fear comparison
with bison, with the twins,
indeed with any
of ox ancestry.

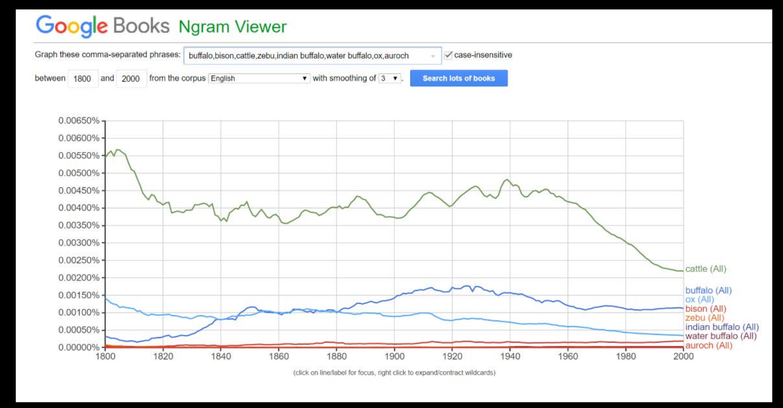
Clean copy of "The Buffalo" by Marianne Moore.
The Complete Poems of Marianne Moore, 1982.

Following an initial read-through of the poem: **What does this mean?**
Subsequent research and analysis would be necessary…



Annotation map of "The Buffalo".

To derive meaning from the poem, it was necessary to hand-trace through the poem and map out various allusions to mythology, art, types of ungulates (i.e. hoofed mammals), and the like. Making sense of Moore's use of distinctions – *this,* not *that* – led to a greater understanding of the poem's breadth and significance.



Above: Graphing Using *Google Books N-Gram Viewer*

This graph demonstrates the frequency of various ungulates over time in English fiction from the years 1800-2000.

Below: Summarizer Algorithm via *Algorithmia.com*

An example of a natural language processing (NLP) algorithm called a *summarizer*. This implementation of a summarizer cut down "The Buffalo" to ten lines. Using the summarizer brought forth interesting questions such as the significance of whitespace: How could one account for the sometimes ambiguous, yet often important role of whitespace in poetry like "The Buffalo"?

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To read the work of modernist poet Marianne Moore is to become an **interdisciplinary explorer**.